This expansion ended the power of the Shan Dynasty that had taken control of northern Burma after the Mongol invasion and had sought to remove Buddhist influence[29] from that region. The renewed Ava Dynasty again allowed Buddhism to spread. Most rulers were Buddhist and more and more of the population was converted.

The Ava Dynasty was succeeded by the Konbaung Dynasty (1752–1885). This period saw the emergence of Burma as a major regional power. It also saw the foundation of Mandalay (in 1857) as the capital of the new state. This assertive and aggressive dynasty won victory in wars against neighbouring Siam, and the resultant boost of wealth and power allowed the kingdom to annex Arakan in 1784.

But this then triggered a series of wars with the British, which led to the loss of Arakan by 1826. Full annexation of the rest of the country by the British followed in 1886.

In terms of religion, by the nineteenth century there had been a degree of fusion between state and religion, as the king saw himself as a protector of all Buddhist monasteries including those in provinces occupied by the British[30] after their conquest of Arakan. Though this linkage between religion and state fell apart after the British had conquered the entire country, it remained an important issue for many Burmese Buddhist nationalists.

In their turn, the British were mostly indifferent towards organised Buddhism and a number of monasteries fell into disrepair or were abandoned.[31] The British took a secular view of the administration of their colonies, mostly out of necessity, and especially refused to be dragged into disputes about religious practice and monastic discipline[32] within the Buddhist community. This indifference indirectly undermined the monastic structure because, by refusing to appoint a head of the *sangha* who would oversee discipline in the different monasteries,[33] the British allowed the hierarchical structures so critical to Theravada Buddhism to fall apart. Some Buddhists saw this as part of a British plot to promote Christianity but a more plausible explanation is simply one of disinterest. The consequence was a degree of fragmentation and the loss of an organised Buddhist voice. Some in the early nationalist movements took little inspiration from Buddhism as such,[34] but others considered regaining independence as a precondition for protecting Burma’s Buddhist heritage.[35]